Ultimate Project Manager — User Guide

15-tab project management system for Excel and Google Sheets. Enter projects and tasks once; dashboards, calendars, the Kanban board and the Gantt chart update automatically.

What's in this folder

File	Use it for
Excel/Ultimate_Project_Manager_Excel_DEMO.xlsx	Excel (Microsoft 365, Excel 2019/2021, Excel 2016) with demo data so you can explore
Excel/Ultimate_Project_Manager_Excel_BLANK.xlsx	Same workbook, no demo rows: start your real workspace here
Google_Sheets/Ultimate_Project_Manager_GoogleSheets_DEMO.xlsx	Import into Google Sheets (demo data)
Google_Sheets/Ultimate_Project_Manager_GoogleSheets_BLANK.xlsx	Import into Google Sheets (blank)

The Google Sheets edition is built from the same generator, adapted for Google Sheets: Arial font, plain ranges with filters (Google Sheets doesn't import Excel Table objects cleanly), no sheet protection (use Data › Protect sheets and ranges instead), and conditional formatting that only refers to its own sheet.

Installation / import

Excel: open the .xlsx file. If you see "Protected View", click *Enable Editing*. The file has no macros.

Google Sheets:

1. Go to drive.google.com › New › File upload, and choose the *GoogleSheets* .xlsx file.
2. Right-click the uploaded file › Open with › Google Sheets.
3. File › Save as Google Sheets. This gives you a native Google Sheet; you can delete the uploaded .xlsx afterwards.
4. Check File › Settings › Locale (for example United States) so dates read the way you expect.

The 15 tabs

#	Tab	Section	Purpose
1	Setup	Setup	Workspace details, currency, week start, every dropdown list
2	All-in-One Dashboard	Dashboards	14 KPI cards, 4 charts, upcoming and overdue lists, recent activity, team workload, project performance
3	Monthly Calendar	Dashboards	Pick a year and month. Shows tasks due (coloured by category), project deadlines and scheduled blocks
4	Weekly Calendar	Dashboards	Monday–Sunday, 7 AM–8 PM time grid, tasks due, daily workload and weekly statistics
5	Project Overview	Projects	Portfolio table: progress, budget, actual, remaining and health are calculated
6	Project Manager	Projects	Pick a project to see its details, timeline, team, objectives, deliverables, milestones, dependencies, risks and notes
7	Project Budget	Projects	Planned vs actual budget lines, utilisation, alerts, category summary
8	Variable Tasks	Tasks	Main database of one-time tasks (500 rows)
9	Recurring Tasks	Tasks	Daily, weekly, biweekly, monthly, quarterly, annual or custom repeats, with the next date calculated
10	Task Schedule	Tasks	Time blocks (date, start and end time). Feeds the Weekly Calendar
11	Task Filter	Tasks	Filter by 10 criteria, including keyword search
12	Decision Matrix	Extras	Weighted scoring of 3 options against up to 10 criteria

#	Tab	Section	Purpose
13	Kanban Board	Extras	5 columns built from the first five Task Statuses
14	Gantt Chart	Extras	Timeline drawn from task dates, in daily or weekly view
15	Instructions	Extras	In-workbook help

Getting started (10 minutes)

1. **Setup:** type your name and workspace, then choose a currency and a week start. Replace the Team Members with your team. Adjust the categories if you like.
2. **Project Overview:** add a row for each project. Fill in the name, category, manager, start date, due date, priority and status. Project IDs (P-001…) are already filled in.
3. **Project Budget:** pick the Project ID, choose a category, and enter the Planned Budget. Add the Actual Expenses as money is spent.
4. **Variable Tasks:** add tasks and link each one to a project with the dropdown. Keep Status and Progress up to date.
5. Optionally, add **Recurring Tasks** and **Task Schedule** blocks.
6. Open the **All-in-One Dashboard**.

Cell colours

Colour	Meaning
Light blue	Input: type a value or choose one from the dropdown
Light grey	Formula: don't overwrite
White	Information
Light teal	Positive result
Light red	Warning or negative result
Lavender	Optional or system list

How the automation works (formula guide)

- **Today.** Every "today" calculation reads *Setup › Effective today*, which is =IF(override="",TODAY(),override). Type a date into the override to see the whole workbook as of that date.
- **Status logic.** The 5th Task Status (default "Completed") means *done* everywhere. The first five Task Statuses become the Kanban columns. Projects with the status Planning or In Progress count as *active*.
- **Project roll-ups** (Project Overview):
  - Progress is AVERAGEIFS over each task's effective progress; a task marked Completed counts as 100%.
  - Budget and Actual are SUMIFS over Project Budget by Project ID.
  - Task counts use COUNTIFS.
  - Health is a decision chain: Completed › Cancelled › Overdue › Over budget › At risk › On track.
- **Filtered and sorted lists.** Helper columns on *Variable Tasks* (headed in grey) give matching rows a running number (1, 2, 3…). The dashboard lists, Task Filter, Kanban and Gantt fetch those rows with INDEX/MATCH. Upcoming and overdue lists are sorted with SMALL() on a rank value (due date plus a tiny row offset). This method gives the same results in Excel 2010+, Microsoft 365, Google Sheets and LibreOffice, with no dynamic-array formulas.
- **Calendars.** Each task gets a key made of its due date and a running number (46333|1, 46333|2…). A calendar cell looks up date|1 and date|2, and project deadlines work the same way.
- **Recurring next date:**
  - Day-based frequencies (daily, weekly, biweekly, custom) add whole intervals to the start date: start + ROUNDUP((base−start)/step,0)×step.

  - Month-based frequencies (monthly, quarterly, annually) use EDATE, so month-end dates stay valid.
  - The base date is the later of today and the day after *Last Completed*. A row shows "Ended" after the End Date and "Paused" when its status is Paused.
- **Gantt.** Conditional-formatting rules compare each timeline column's date with the task's start and end dates.
  - Darker blue shows the share of the bar covered by progress.
  - Teal means completed, red means overdue, and ◆ marks a milestone (start date = due date).
  - The amber column is today.
- **Currency.** Amounts are stored as plain numbers. The Setup currency symbol appears in KPI labels.

Demo data

Rows marked **DEMO DATA** belong to a fictional company, "Northwind Studio". The demo has 8 projects, 60 tasks, 18 budget lines, 10 recurring tasks, 22 schedule blocks, 25 project details and 1 decision.

Remove it: the easiest way is to start from the BLANK file. To clear the demo file by hand, select the light-blue cells that contain data on Project Overview, Project Budget, Variable Tasks, Recurring Tasks, Task Schedule, the Project Manager database and Decision Matrix, then press Delete. Never delete whole rows or the grey helper columns.

Capacity

The workbook has room for 100 projects, 500 tasks, 500 budget lines, 200 recurring tasks, 300 schedule blocks and 300 project details. To go beyond that, copy the last row's formulas further down. In Excel, a table grows when you type directly below it. For a separate workspace, duplicate the file.

Troubleshooting

Symptom	Fix
A task isn't on the dashboard, calendar or Gantt	It needs a Task Name. Date views also need a Due Date (and a Start Date for the Gantt). Pick the Project from the dropdown so the name matches exactly
A Kanban card is missing	Its Status must be one of the first five Task Statuses. Each column shows up to 15 cards
A dropdown is empty	Its source list on Setup is empty
"+N more" appears on the calendar	More than 2 tasks are due that day. Use Task Filter with a date range to see them all
A date shows as a number	Format the cell as a Date
You can't type on a dashboard tab (Excel)	Display tabs are protected against accidental edits. Use Review › Unprotect Sheet (there's no password)
A chart looks slightly different in Google Sheets	Click the chart › Edit chart. The data ranges are kept

Quality assurance performed

- Every workbook (2 editions × demo/blank) was recalculated headlessly in LibreOffice: 19,685 formulas each, **0 errors**.
- An independent Python script (build/validate_project_manager.py) re-calculates the expected results from the demo data and compares them with the spreadsheet's values. It covers 530 checks across all four files:
  - KPIs and sorted lists
  - Project roll-ups
  - Recurring next dates and occurrences this month
  - Kanban
  - Monthly and weekly calendar placement

  - Gantt
  - Task Filter
  - Decision Matrix
  - Blank-state messages
- The date logic was re-tested with "today" set to Sep 1 2026, Oct 15 2026, Dec 31 2026 and Jan 4 2027, all passing.

Not yet verified: the files have not been opened in Microsoft Excel or Google Sheets themselves, because neither was available in the build environment.

- Formulas are limited to functions documented for both products: SUMIFS, COUNTIFS, AVERAGEIFS, INDEX, MATCH, IFERROR, EDATE, EOMONTH, WEEKNUM, SMALL, LARGE, HYPERLINK and SEARCH.
- Before you sell, open each file once in Excel and in Google Sheets and look through the charts and conditional formatting.